

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

1:1 Template

A repeatable structure for regular one-to-ones that build trust, unblock work and grow the people on your team.

Purpose

The regular one-to-one is the single highest-leverage habit of a good manager, and the first thing that gets dropped when a QA leader is busy. This template gives every 1:1 a light structure so it does not decay into a status update, while keeping it firmly the report's meeting rather than yours. Its purpose is trust, growth and unblocking — not project tracking.

The guiding principle: this is their time. You are there mostly to listen, to remove obstacles, and to help them grow. Status can be gathered elsewhere; the 1:1 is for the things that only surface when someone feels safe and unhurried.

When to use it

- A recurring 1:1 with each direct report — weekly or fortnightly, protected and rarely cancelled.
- Especially in the first weeks with an inherited team, when you are still earning trust.
- When someone seems disengaged, stuck or overloaded and you need to understand why.
- As the steady backbone that makes occasional harder conversations (feedback, performance, career) far easier to have.

Instructions

1. Keep a shared, running document per person so both of you can add agenda items between meetings and see actions carried over.
2. Let them set the agenda first. Their topics come before yours.
3. Open with how they actually are, not with a task list. Mean it.
4. Listen far more than you talk. Silence is fine; resist filling it.
5. Surface blockers and note what you will personally take away to remove.
6. Touch on growth and career regularly, not only at review time.
7. Give and invite feedback in both directions — including feedback on you.
8. Close by agreeing clear actions and owners, and carry them to next time so nothing is dropped.

Worked example

A fortnightly 1:1 between the QA lead and Dan Whitmore, the automation engineer who is quietly burning out maintaining the flaky, low-trust Selenium suite alone.

Section	Notes from the conversation
How are you, really?	Dan admits he is running on empty. Every release he firefights suite flakiness late into the evening, and nobody notices unless it breaks. He feels invisible.
Their agenda	Wants to know whether automation is even valued here after last year's failed "automate everything" push, and whether he should be looking to move on.
Wins since last time	Quietly stabilised the login and checkout smoke tests — they have not falsely failed in two weeks. Nobody had thanked him; I did, specifically.
Blockers	He owns the suite alone; developers will not touch it, so flakiness never gets fixed at source. Unstable staging causes a chunk of the false failures.
Growth / career	He is keen to move from lone suite-maintainer towards helping the whole team own automation — a genuine step up in scope and influence.
Feedback both ways	I fed back that his stabilisation work is exactly the judgement we need more of. He fed back that he needs me to make suite health visible to engineering leadership, not leave it buried.
Actions & owners	(1) Me: raise shared ownership of the suite with Priya and propose developers fixing flakiness at source. (2) Me: add suite health as a visible team metric. (3) Dan: draft a short "which tests are worth keeping" triage. Carry all three to next 1:1.

What this 1:1 achieved: it caught a burnout and retention risk before it became a resignation, converted an isolated engineer into a partner on a strategy change, and gave the QA lead a concrete, credible action (shared suite ownership) to take upward. None of it would have surfaced in a status meeting.

Blank reusable version

Section	Notes
How are you, really?	
Their agenda (their topics first)	
Wins since last time	
Blockers (what can I remove?)	
Growth / career	
Feedback both ways	
Actions & owners (carry forward)	

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Turning the 1:1 into a status update you could have got from the board. Cancelling it whenever you are busy — which signals the person is low priority exactly when they need you. Doing most of the talking. Only

discussing career at appraisal time. Taking away actions and then never doing them, which teaches the person that raising blockers is pointless. Never inviting feedback on yourself. And keeping no running notes, so the same problem is "raised for the first time" every fortnight.

How to interpret / use it well

- Protect the slot fiercely. A 1:1 you rarely cancel is worth more than a longer one you frequently do.
- Read the pattern over time, not just the single meeting. Three quiet "I'm fine"s in a row from someone usually talkative is data.
- Your follow-through is the trust-builder. Removing even one small blocker they raised proves the meeting is real.
- Adjust the depth to the person and the moment — some weeks are logistics, some weeks are the conversation that changes everything.
- Feed what you learn into the Coaching Plan for growth and, where needed, the Performance Conversation Planner — the 1:1 is where you notice, those are where you act.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Ask "what is the most frustrating part of your work right now?" and then say nothing until they answer properly. The best blockers, the early burnout signals and the retention risks almost always live in the pause after that question — the one most managers rush to fill.